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Just the day before, on 3 March, the prime minister had held extensive briefings with a team of scientists and bureaucrats from the PMO and across ministries.[3] Just like every political leader in the world, he was facing a quandary. What was India's balancing line? Should we protect the vulnerable and minority populations while allowing the contagion to spread through society or lock down the country and the economy to keep the virus at a manageable level? How quickly would the disease overwhelm our healthcare system? Did we have enough doctors, nurses and frontline workers to be able to afford to let the virus run unchecked? What about hospital beds, oxygenated beds, ventilators and other such essential supplies?

Most medical and scientific advice regarding the evolution of COVID-19 was provided first hand to the prime minister by the team comprising primarily Dr V.K. Paul, Prof. VijayRaghavan, Prof. Dr Balram Bhargava of the ICMR, AIIMS Director Dr Randeep Guleria and the in-house bureaucrats in the PMO, some of whom were qualified medical doctors and community medicine experts. This team briefed the prime minister about how social distancing, wearing face masks, handwashing and repeatedly sanitizing seemed to be the only ways to keep the virus at bay. Although evidence on how the virus was spreading was still emerging, and most research around the world was focusing on surface transmission as the main source of spread, our team of scientists seemed to be convinced—based on data from emerging case studies globally and the high doubling rate—that the most likely scenario was of the virus spreading through suspended aerosols in the air when an infected person spoke, coughed or sneezed. This was deeply concerning for us, since not only were we the second most populous country in the world but our population density was almost as high as 460 people per sq. km. It would be a formidable challenge to educate the Indian people on what COVID-19 measures would entail. Clear, firm communication would be paramount.

In the meeting, Dr Paul expressed to the prime minister, 'This is a war that science will win for us, Sir, through ground-breaking drugs and vaccines. We must support and encourage our scientists, industry and scientific organizations to develop this ammunition for our arsenal.'